

Part II — The Apparition

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The Father asks the actresses if they would mind hanging their hats and mantles on the pegs at the back of the upper platform. They climb up to do so, half-amused, not knowing why. The Father asks them to look toward the door upstage. The door opens. Madame Pace appears on the upper level — though she was not in the original six, and no one called her, and no one walks through a stage door on cue. The Step-Daughter, on the platform with her, recognises her at once.

This is the production's strangest scene, and the most architecturally bold. A Character not in the original cast list is summoned onto the upper level by the very arrangement of the stage — by the hats on the pegs, by the shop window the Property Man has set up (the sign reads *robes et manteaux*), by the folding screen. She is played by a performer of her own — no Player steps into a costume in view of the house; the door opens and she is simply there, the way an apparition enters a body. She is fat, bleach-blonde, rouged — an Italian-Swiss woman who has lived in Lausanne long enough to half-forget her first language and never quite learn her second. She speaks English in a thick accent — Italian-Swiss and French both worn into it — and the actors laugh at the sound of her before they understand what it is saying. What it is saying is a procurement transaction. She is a bookkeeper of the trade — the silk the Mother has ruined, the column that must balance, the cash in the blue envelope, the chicken not slaughtered where the hen can see. The Step-Daughter begins to play the scene of the atelier with her, drawn back into a room she has been in before.

Then the Mother sees her, from the lower floor. The Mother, who has barely spoken in this play, looks up at the upper platform and erupts: *You old devil! You murderess!* Her voice crosses from below to above. And — surprising herself — it does not stop. She names the years, the kitchen, the silk, the tea she drank in Madame Pace's kitchen every Wednesday while her own daughter was just down the corridor. She half-knew, and let herself not know, because the alternative was the children going hungry. The temperature in the room collapses in seconds. The scene of the shop cannot be played in the presence of its witness. The play breaks its own scene, and the actors, watching from the wings, do not understand what they are watching. The Mother spends what she has, and is restored to silence by the end of the part — but she has used her voice, for the first time in the production, and the company has heard it.

Playing the apparition. Madame Pace is full comedy on her arrival and full chill by her exit — the company laughs at her accent before they understand what they are laughing at, and the laugh must curdle in the throat as the ledger comes clear (*he pay cash*). The Mother's outburst is the silent centre of the play finding voice for the only time: let it come out faster than her body can carry it, then cost her everything.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

*The door at the back of stage opens and **Madame Pace** enters and takes a few steps forward. She is a fat, oldish woman with puffy oxygenated hair, rouged and powdered, dressed with a comical elegance in black silk. Round her waist is a long silver chain from which hangs a pair of scissors. The audience should read her at first as absurd — an apparition out of a comic operetta, conjured from the costume department of every small shop in Lausanne that has ever overcharged a foreigner. She has come, however, from somewhere real: a back room off the rue de Bourg, where the accounts book lies open on a desk and a*

customer is waiting. The comedy is her front. The scissors at her waist are not. The **Step-Daughter** runs over to her at once amid the stupor of the actors.

Triumph, not welcome — Madame Pace's arrival vindicates every word the Step-Daughter has said and strips the room of any comfortable distance.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [turning towards her]. There she is! There she is!

Radiant because he needs the stage to confirm his version of events; Pace's entrance feels to him like proof, not accusation.

THE FATHER [radiant]. It's she! I said so, didn't I? There she is!

What he cannot explain becomes, by reflex, a violation of the rules he is there to enforce — the indignation is purely self-protective.

THE MANAGER [conquering his surprise, and then becoming indignant]. What sort of a trick is this?

Hand pressed to chest, the Leading Man checks that he still exists — the real threat is not the missing script but his own sudden insubstantiality beside these intruders.

PLAYER 1 [almost at the same time — a hand pressed flat to his chest, as if checking he is still there]. What's going to happen next? Have we lost the script entirely?

The youngest player, badly unnerved: he reaches for the moment she entered and finds none to put her in — the uncanny lands hardest on him.

PLAYER 3. Where did *she* come from? She wasn't here a moment ago. She wasn't anywhere.

Bravado as a covering action — she names it a trick to steady herself, but the assertion curdles into a question she needs someone else to answer.

PLAYER 2. It's some trick. Someone arranged this. [the certainty leaves her] ...Didn't they?

He turns the actors' protest into the play's credo — the stage has just made something truer than any performance; the conjured Pace outranks the actress who would fake her.

THE FATHER [dominating the protests]. Excuse me — all of you. Why so eager to destroy, in the name of your ordinary little truth, a thing the stage itself has just conjured into being? Which of your actresses was to play Madame Pace? Here she is — Madame Pace herself. Any actress you cast would be less true than the woman standing there. That is all.

But the scene between the Step-Daughter and Madame Pace has already begun despite the protest of the actors and the reply of The Father. It has begun quietly, naturally, in a manner impossible for the stage. So when the actors, called to attention by The Father, turn round and see Madame Pace, who has placed one hand under the Step-Daughter's chin to raise her head, they observe her at first with great attention, but hearing her speak in an unintelligible manner their interest begins to wane.

Two identical monosyllables, stalling — the Manager is buying time while his authority catches up with an event he has no procedure for.

THE MANAGER. Well? well?

The cupped ear, the projecting bearing — professional habit is the only instrument the company has left for processing the uncanny.

PLAYER 1 [cupping a hand to his ear, the bearing of a man used to being heard at the back of the house]. What does she say? Madame — speak up.

Demanding volume is also a demand for safety: if it is loud enough to be theatre, it is contained enough not to be real.

PLAYER 3. Louder! Louder please!

She draws a line between two kinds of speech — loud shaming accusation aimed at the Father, and the soft transactional quiet of Pace's world — knowing both from the inside.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [leaving Madame Pace, who smiles a Sphinx-like smile, and advancing towards the actors]. Louder? Louder? What on earth are you talking about? These aren't matters one shouts at the top of one's voice. If I spoke them loud, sir, it was to *shame* him and have my revenge. [Indicates **Father**.] But for Madame it's quite a different matter.

Asking characters who actually lived that privacy to simulate it for an audience's comfort is an unwitting cruelty the Manager cannot hear in his own instruction.

THE MANAGER. Indeed? indeed? But here, you know, people have got to make themselves heard, my dear. Even we who are on the stage can't hear you — what will it be when the public's in the theatre? You've got to pretend to be alone in a room at the back of a shop where no one can hear you — and still make the whole house hear.

The Step-Daughter, level and unhurried, makes a sign of disagreement two or three times with her finger.

More alarmed than curious — a single 'no' from a character is insubordination to the whole theatrical contract he manages.

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by no?

The quiet warning reintroduces the Father as the hidden listener; the danger is not the audience but the man behind the door who already knows.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [low, no theatrics]. There's someone who will hear us if she [Indicating *Madame Pace*.] speaks out loud.

The Manager's consternation and the actors' laughter are the same reflex — converting genuine dread into social noise.

THE MANAGER [in consternation]. What? Have you got someone else to spring on us now? [The *Actors* burst out laughing.]

The offer to step behind the door is cooperative and self-serving at once: he can re-enter as the character rather than the accused man standing in full light.

THE FATHER. No, no sir. She is alluding to me. I've got to be here — there behind that door, in waiting; and Madame Pace knows it. In fact, if you will allow me, I'll go there at once, so I can be quite ready. [Moves away.]

An appeal to theatrical convention not to protect the scene but to reassert authority over a sequence he did not choreograph.

THE MANAGER [stopping him]. No! Wait! wait! We must observe the conventions of the theatre. Before you are ready...

Not artistic enthusiasm — she is hunting the moment of exposure and fears any delay will allow the Father or the Manager to soften what she needs left raw.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [interrupting him]. No, get on with it at once! I'm just dying, I tell you, to act this scene. If he's ready, I'm more than ready.

Insisting on the Pace scene first as a director's procedure, unaware he is asking her to rehearse the prelude to her own degradation on demand.

THE MANAGER [shouting]. But, my dear young lady, first of all, we must have the scene between you and this lady... [Indicates *Madame Pace*.] Do you understand?...

Clipped and matter-of-fact, she drains the scene of sentiment — the story has been rehearsed so many times it has become inventory.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Good Heavens! She's been telling me what you know already: that my mother's work is badly done again, that the material's ruined; and that if I want her to continue to help us in our misery I must be patient...

The elaborate self-introduction is a performance of respectability that names its own corruption: the ledger-logic — 'the book, she balance' — is the horror dressed as bookkeeping.

MADAME PACE *[coming forward with an air of great importance, hand pressed to her chest, very pleased indeed to be here].* Good morning, good morning, sir! Here I am, here I am — so sorry I am late, so sorry — the traffic, the trams in this town, always the same. *[A small bow to the room; the silver chain at her waist swings once.]* Madame Pace, sir — dresses and coats, off the rue de Bourg, the courtyard near Saint-François. You know me. All Lausanne, it know me. Forty years. Forty years in this canton, sir, and never one bad word about Pace. *[Smiling, the smile of a hostess at her own front door.]* I no wanta be hard, eh? I no wanta take advantage. I am a good woman, sir. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Only — the lady over there, she ruin the silk. Again. The third time this month, sir — the third time. Silk, sir, you no pay with the tears. Somebody must pay. The mother, she pay with the hands — or the little one, she pay. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Either way, sir — the book, she balance. Pace, she always balance the book.

Note. Madame Pace speaks in a heavy accent, not in another language — an Italian-Swiss woman who has lived in French Lausanne too long and not long enough. The foreignness lives in the music of the voice and the broken grammar; the page keeps the words plain and lets the actor carry the sound. Played for full comedy on her arrival; played for full chill by her exit. The audience must laugh at her first line. They must regret laughing by her last.

Genuinely alarmed beneath the comedy — Pace's accent reduces operatic villainy to something petty and mercantile, which turns out to be worse than a proper melodrama villain.

THE MANAGER *[alarmed].* What? What? She talks like that? *[The Actors burst out laughing again.]*

She laughs with the actors, but her laughter is knowing and a little cruel — the accent is funny precisely because it made her own degradation sound ridiculous.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[also laughing].* Yes yes, that's the way she talks — that accent of hers! Most comical it is!

By placing her clients on the same rhythm as the bells of Saint-François, Pace reveals that her trade is built into the town's civic heartbeat.

MADAME PACE. It seem not very polite, gentlemen, to laugh at me — when I try to speak proper for the customers. My customers — eh — they no laugh, sir. They come back. Wednesday afternoon. Friday afternoon. Sometimes the Sunday, after the church. *[A small shrug, the smile.]* Like the bells of Saint-François. You hear those bells, sir, in this town? Three time a week. *Bom. Bom. Bom.*

Delighted by 'comic relief,' he misreads exploitation as theatrical texture — a professional error so spectacular it becomes its own indictment.

THE MANAGER. Perfect! Of course! Of course! Let her talk like that! Just what we want. Talk just like that, Madame, if you please! The effect's guaranteed — exactly what we needed, a bit of comic relief to lift all this gloom. Of course she talks like that! Magnificent!

She reclaims the laugh as a weapon, showing how Pace's ledger-language makes violation sound like commerce and how that very absurdity is what lets the paying men live with themselves.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Magnificent? Certainly! When such things are said to a girl in language of that kind, the effect is certain, since it seems almost a joke. One feels inclined to laugh when one hears her recite her inventory of clients — clean ones, polite ones, paying ones — as if she were counting bolts of silk. Nice old gentleman, eh, Madame?

Portrait of the 'polite' client delivered with the serenity of a satisfied hostess — she describes the erasure of the girl's name and face as though praising a reliable supplier.

MADAME PACE. Not so old, my dear. Not so old. Forty-five, maybe fifty — the age when a man have money in the pocket and shame in the throat, eh, sir? The best age, my dear, in my long experience. He clean. He polite. *[The smile, unchanged.]* He pay cash. The blue envelope on the little mahogany table, you no even gotta look at his face, you no even gotta count. The polite ones, sir — they count for you. He no ask your name. He no need to. He call you little one, he call you dear, he call you whatever please him — for that little while the name belong to him. *[The smile.]* And if you no like him? Eh — no scandal. Nobody talk. It stay quiet, like everything in this town. Like the silk. Like the sewing. Like everything that get ruin in Pace's shop. The lady know. The lady stay quiet too.

Years of self-silencing finally outrun her body — the Wednesday tea, the knowledge half-held, the deliberate not-seeing all confessed in the same breath as the accusation.

THE MOTHER *[jumping up amid the amazement and consternation of the actors who had not been noticing her. They move to restrain her — and the voice that comes out of her is the one she has not used for years, and once it starts it comes out faster than her body can carry it].* You old devil! You murderess! *[Trembling, but the voice does not stop.]* Three years you took her from me. Three years. I sat at your kitchen table with the needle in my hand, and the tea you served me — your kind tea, your terrible kind tea — and somewhere I knew. Somewhere, in the back of my head, I half-knew. But if I let myself know it, the children at home did not eat. So I drank the tea. I drank your tea, madame, every Wednesday, every Friday, sometimes the Sunday — and I did not let myself see that my own daughter was just down the corridor in your back room. *[Her hand, briefly, at her own chest.]* May God forgive me. May God forgive me. I drank the tea.

The rush to calm her mother carries a flicker of fear: the raw voice she hears is the wound beneath the weapon, and it threatens to undo the cold control she has built.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[running over to calm her Mother — and a little frightened, perhaps, by the voice she has just heard come out of her].* Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

Returning to Pace's smile — mistaken for kindness — she names the deepest injury: she believed she had found a friend in her isolation, and that belief was the mechanism of her daughter's exploitation.

THE MOTHER *[she cannot quite stop yet; the voice has been waiting too long].* And the smile, devil. The smile you had for me when I came into the kitchen with the finished sewing. I thought it was a kindness. I thought you were the only person in Lausanne with a kindness in her for a poor widow from another town. May God forgive me — I thought it was a kindness.

Urging calm is as much about composure management as compassion; the scene is threatening to exceed the version of events he has prepared to argue.

THE FATHER *[going to her also, at the same time, the body now beginning to give him away too].* Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

After the torrent, the voice goes short again — collapse back into suppression, with just enough left to demand the source of the memory be removed.

THE MOTHER *[the voice short again now, as if she has spent what she had].* Well then. Take that woman out of my sight.

Practical and protective at once; she is also quietly preventing her mother's pain from being absorbed into theatrical spectacle.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to Manager].* It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

The logical explanation conceals the real motive: the Mother's presence exposes a guilt that his careful philosophical framing cannot survive.

THE FATHER *[to Manager].* They can't be here together. And here's why: that woman wasn't with us when we came. If they are on together, the whole thing is given away. Inevitably. As you see.

| Domesticating the eruption into a staging problem — 'first rough sketch' — so he can feel in charge of something again.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. This is only a first rough sketch — just to get an idea of the various points of the scene, even confusedly... *[Turning to the **Mother** and leading her to her chair.]* Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene...

*Meanwhile, the **Step-Daughter**, coming forward again, turns to **Madame Pace**.*

| A stage direction issued by a character: she is now directing the scene she is also living inside.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Come on, Madame, come on!

| A grotesque pastoral — the hen-and-chicken rule makes the exploitation of girls sound like prudent animal husbandry.

MADAME PACE *[offended, but not loud — the offense of a businesswoman whose house rules have been questioned].* Eh no, thank you. The mother present — it is not possible, sir. It is against the rule. I have my method. I have had my method for forty years. The mother she stay in the kitchen with the tea, like always. The little one she come down the corridor when Pace she ring the little bell. *[Lifts a hand, as if to a small invisible bell.]* The business it no close while the mother she watch. The chickens too, sir. Even the chickens — you no kill them where the hen can see. The hen, she scream. The hen, she ruin the meat. It is a rule of the house. House rule. Pace, she keep the house rules.

| Ejecting Madame Pace is the one moment she exercises power — she stages herself as the agent, not the commodity.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Bring on this *old gentleman* who wants to talk so nicely to me. *[Addressing the Company imperiously.]* We've got to do this scene one way or another, haven't we? Come on! *[To **Madame Pace**.]* You can go!

| A contract renewal in disguise: by naming the debt, the hunger, the next silk, Pace ensures the Step-Daughter leaves still owing, still findable.

MADAME PACE *[adjusting the silver chain at her waist; the scissors swing once].* Yes yes, of course. I go. I go. But my dear — you remember. Without Pace, nothing. You still in the school with your braids and your stomach empty, your little sister at home crying for the bread that is not in the house. You owe it all to me. To Pace. *[Pauses at the door. The smile returned, calm now, almost tender.]* And when the lady ruin the next silk — and she will, my dear, she always do — you know where to find me. *[Beat. The voice softer, the smile unchanged.]* There is always the next silk, my dear. There is always the debt. There is always Pace. *[The scissors swing once more at her waist.]* Don't you forget the name. *[Exits. Not furious. Unhurried.]*

| Correcting his posture, cueing his line — she is directing him into the man he was so the stage can convict him.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to the **Father**].* Now you make your entry. No, you needn't go over here. Come here. Let's suppose you've already come in. Like that, yes! I'm here with my head bowed, modest-like. Come on! Out with your voice! Say "Good afternoon, Miss" in that peculiar tone, that special tone...

| Two directors in one room; but his instruction to the Father is also an admission that he cannot resist seeing the scene played out.

THE MANAGER. Excuse me, but are you the Manager, or am I? *[To the **Father**, who looks undecided and perplexed.]* Get on with it, man! Go down there to the back of the stage. You needn't go off. Then come right forward here.

*The **Father** does as he is told, looking troubled and perplexed at first. But as soon as he begins to move, the reality of the action affects him, and he begins to smile and to be more natural. The **Actors** watch intently.*

| The whispered 'ready?' to the Prompter shows the machinery of theatre swallowing a live wound: the scene is already being turned into a text to be recorded.

THE MANAGER *[sotto voce, quickly to the **Prompter** in his box].* Ready! ready? Get ready to write now.

Composure is the character's technique — the mask of normalcy worn by a man who has done this before and knows exactly how to wear it.
THE FATHER [coming forward, composed now — this is the scene, this is the man he was, that man did not show what he was feeling]. Good afternoon, Miss.

A lifetime of revulsion held behind a single decorous phrase — the bow is the posture of submission, the disgust is the truth beneath it.
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [head bowed down slightly, with restrained disgust]. Good afternoon!

Not conscience — it is the calculation of risk, dressed briefly in the clothes of surprise, as he realises how young she is.
THE FATHER [looks under her hat which partly covers her face. Perceiving she is very young, he makes an exclamation, partly of surprise, partly of fear lest he compromise himself in a risky adventure]. Ah... but... ah... I say... this isn't the first time you've come here, is it?

Two syllables that confirm she has been here before and has long since run out of energy to pretend otherwise.
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [the rehearsed bow — no softness in it]. No sir.

Escalating from 'once' to 'more than once,' he reassures himself that prior visits have established a precedent that removes his responsibility.
THE FATHER. You've been here before, eh? [Then seeing her nod agreement.] More than once? [Waits for her to answer, looks under her hat, smiles, and then says.] Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

She forestalls him on the hat because she will not be touched before she chooses to be — removing it herself is the last act of self-possession available to her.
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [anticipating him and with veiled disgust]. No sir... I'll do it myself. [Takes it off quickly.]

*The **Mother**, who watches the progress of the scene with **The Son** beside her, the Child-bundle held tight in her arms and the Boy-chair pulled in against her knee, is on thorns; and follows with varying expressions of sorrow, indignation, anxiety, and horror the words and actions of the other two. From time to time she hides her face in her hands and sobs.*

Muffled behind her hands, the prayer is not theatrical; it is the sound of a parent for whom witnessing has become indistinguishable from complicity.
THE MOTHER [without lifting her head from her hands]. Oh, my God. My God.

The gift of a smarter hat is the transaction dressed as gallantry — delivered with the fluency of a man who has rehearsed this scene before.
THE FATHER [playing his part with a touch of gallantry]. Give it to me! I'll put it down. [Takes hat from her hands.] But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

A purely professional anxiety about the hats that, by its absurd timing, accidentally names the commodification happening on stage.
PLAYER 1 [interrupting — protective of the company's property, the senior actor surfacing through the wig]. I say... those are *our* hats, you know.

His fury at the interruption shows captivation: he wants the scene to continue more than he wants decorum restored, so he protects it.
THE MANAGER [furious]. Silence! silence! Don't try and be funny, if you please... We're playing the scene now I'd have you notice. [To the **Step-Daughter**.] Begin again, please!

Not a line — a character who has already decided where this ends, holding her position against the transaction's momentum.
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [continuing]. No thank you, sir.

Invoking Pace as the silent partner whose approval lubricates the exchange, he shows the full triangulation of the arrangement.
THE FATHER. Oh, come now. Don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here; and then — Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

The refusal carries its real reason just below the surface — the first hint of the black dress and what it means.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no! I couldn't wear it!

The seducer's all-purpose solvent: every obstacle is reframed as a social inconvenience, never as a moral one.

THE FATHER. Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

Touching the black dress once, she lets mourning enter the transaction — a single restrained gesture that changes everything in the room.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[level, not pleading]*. No, it's not that. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her black dress, once.]*

The pause before 'in mourning' is the play's most nakedly exposed moment of ethical failure: the audience watches a man choose a polished apology over an honest reckoning.

THE FATHER *[a beat — the smallest pause. He did not, in fact, say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said something else. The audience must see the lie being made in real time.]*. ... in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm — I'm frightfully sorry...

She swallows disgust and forces a smile — not forgiveness, but a bid to seize the scene back before the Father narrates it for her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[forcing herself to conquer her indignation and nausea]*. Stop! Stop! It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. *[Tries to smile.]* I must forget that I am dressed so...

Scissors applied to the transcript: pain that can't be shaped into theatre gets cut, and the Manager calls the remainder "fine."

THE MANAGER *[interrupting and turning to the **Prompter**]*. Stop a minute! Stop! Don't write that down. Cut out that last bit. *[Then to the **Father** and **Step-Daughter**.]* Fine! it's going fine! *[To the **Father** only.]* And now you can go on as we arranged. *[To the **Actors**.]* Pretty good that scene, where he offers her the hat, eh?

Hunger, not impatience — she wants the seduction played to its ugliest end before anyone onstage can soften it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. The best's coming now. Why can't we go on?

Treating it lightly is the house rule: the Manager smooths trauma into entertainment so audiences can watch without being hurt.

THE MANAGER. Have a little patience! *[To the **Actors**.]* Of course, it must be treated rather lightly.

Vanity rushes in to fill the vacuum — he claims ownership of a scene he hasn't entered and a pain he cannot touch.

PLAYER 1. Still — with a bit of go in it. Which I, of course, will provide.